

STARTER

Common Refusal Reasons & How to Avoid Them

Schengen Area - Short-Stay Tourist Visa (Type C)

Schengen refusals use a standardised EU-wide refusal form, listing the specific ground(s) checked by the consulate under Annex VI of the Visa Code. Most short-stay visa applications are decided without an interview, so your written file and documents carry the full weight of the decision.

The most common specific reasons

1. Insufficient or missing travel medical insurance

Insurance is a hard, checked requirement here - missing coverage, an amount below the consulate's stated minimum, or a policy that doesn't cover the whole Schengen area or your full trip length can each trigger this ground on its own.

2. Insufficient means of subsistence

- Show funds meeting the specific reference amount published by the consulate you applied to, for your stated trip length
- If someone else is funding your trip, include their evidence and a formal sponsorship/invitation declaration in the form that consulate requires - see the Cover Letter and Sponsor templates

3. Doubts about your intention to leave before your visa expires

The consulate isn't convinced you're a genuine short-stay visitor who will leave before your authorised stay ends.

- Evidence ties at home: employment, family, property, or ongoing study
- Keep your stated itinerary and purpose specific and consistent throughout the application

4. Unreliable or unsupported information

Inconsistent dates, unexplained gaps, or documents that don't clearly support the stated purpose all undermine the consulate's confidence in the rest of the file.

5. Applying at the wrong consulate

If your main destination or itinerary doesn't match the consulate you applied to, your application can be refused or redirected - see the "Which consulate is responsible for you?" note in the Application Walkthrough (Starter tier).

YOU CAN APPEAL A SCHENGEN REFUSAL

Unlike some other countries' visitor visas, Schengen refusals do carry a right of appeal - but the specific process, time limit, and authority you appeal to are set by the national law of the member state that refused you, not a single EU-wide procedure. Your refusal form states which authority and deadline apply to your case. See the Refusal Decision Guide (Premium tier).